There can scarcely be a better example of two minds thinking alike than Narendra Modi and Amit Shah. One supplies vision and charisma, the other reinforces it with strategy and execution. Together, they have transformed the Bharatiya Janata Party into the behemoth it is today: the world's largest political party, claiming a membership of 140 million.

Yet size alone has not mattered. Modi-Shah have also instilled a rare work ethic in the organisation. This means unwavering focus on winning elections, be it for the Lok Sabha, a state assembly, or local bodies. Planning begins well in advance, and an entire phalanx dedicated to the task: from central ministers and general secretaries at the apex to *panna pramukh*s at the grassroots. Every aspect—campaign strategy, candidate selection, booth management—is meticulously calibrated, alongside constant outreach, a task made easier by the vast network of RSS cadre. Funds have never been a handicap either, as the BJP remains the top beneficiary of corporate donations to political parties first through electoral bonds and now via electoral trusts.

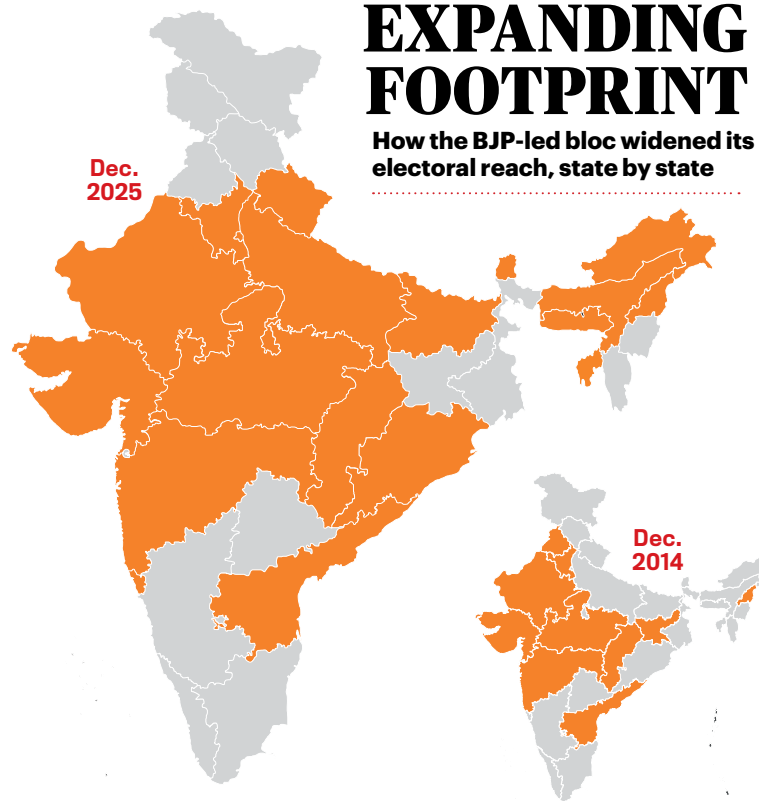
NO ELECTION IS TOO SMALL AND FAILURE NO OPTION IN THE MODI-SHAH POLL PLAYBOOK. DEFEAT IS A CHANCE TO PREPARE FOR THE NEXT TIME

The pursuit of power is relentless, some would say even brutal. Opponents like Arvind Kejriwal can be cut down to size by embroiling them in corruption cases pursued by enforcement agencies; others can have charges dropped if they switch over to the BJP, a la Ajit Pawar in Maharashtra. Nor does ideology come in the way of importing leaders from other parties if they can advance the BJP cause: Himanta Biswa Sarma in Assam, Eknath Shinde in Maharashtra or Jyotiraditya Scindia in Madhya Pradesh. This year also saw the special intensive revision of electoral rolls, which many deem an exercise in voter exclusion aimed at helping the BJP.

At the end of 2025, the BJP's dominance of the Hindi heartland—save Himachal and Chhattisgarh—is complete. In November, the NDA emphatically won Bihar, and now has its sights set firmly on Bengal. The coalition is now in power in 21 of India's 31 states/ UTs with legislatures, nearly double the 11 it governed in late 2014. ■

SAFFRON'S EXPANDING FOOTPRINT

How the BJP-led bloc widened its electoral reach, state by state



DEC. 2025
21 No. of states/ UTs ruled by the NDA

DEC. 2014
11 No. of states/ UTs ruled by the NDA



◀ Yogistan
Apr. 10, 2017

"The first 10 days of Yogi Adityanath's government have seen bureaucrats reporting to work at 10 am and not chewing tobacco in keeping with the CM's drive for punctuality and cleanliness in government offices.... At a gathering in Lucknow, he said, "In the last one week as UP chief minister, I have taken small steps. But I must admit I will never hesitate to take big steps for the people of Uttar Pradesh."